

Title

Peer-facilitated behaviour intervention successfully reduced internalized stigma and promoted HIV prevention advocacy in PLHIV: findings from a Ugandan randomized trial

Abstract

Background: Stigma remains a barrier to HIV prevention engagement. We tested whether structured peer-facilitated counselling could enable PLHIV to become community prevention advocates. **Methods:** Two hundred ten PLHIV in Uganda were randomized to an 8-module peer-led behaviour intervention or control. Participants completed assessments at baseline, 6, 12, and 18 months. **Primary outcomes:** internalized stigma (assessed via 8-item standardized instrument) and prevention advocacy behaviour. **Secondary outcomes:** disclosure to social network members; among 599 network members, HIV testing uptake and condom use frequency. **Results:** The intervention group reported significantly lower internalized stigma compared with control at 18 months ($p=0.002$). Self-reported prevention advocacy activities were higher in intervention participants (mean 12.4 versus 6.8 activities in past year; $p<0.001$). Advocacy self-efficacy increased by 37% in intervention versus 8% in controls ($p<0.001$). Among social network members, those aware of a network member's HIV advocacy efforts showed higher HIV testing rates (58% versus 42%; $p=0.008$) and reported more consistent condom use. **Conclusions:** Peer-facilitated behaviour change successfully reduced stigma and activated prevention advocacy, with measurable indirect benefits to social networks.